TURNING THE TIDE

As Goa's pandemic-hit tourism sector slowly returns to life, CM Pramod Sawant fervently hopes to see revival in the stalled mining industry as well

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FORGING AHEAD Goa chief minister Pramod Sawant

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As winter finally begins to descend on north India and the holiday season is upon a pandemic-free population, India's party hotspot Goa is gearing up to welcome back the tourists again to its smooth, sandy beaches. The tourist—domestic as well as international—is the coastal state's greatest hope to bring its economy back on track post the hiccups of the economic slowdown and later the Covid lockdowns. The domestic tourists are back, but the dollar spenders, or foreign tourists, still elude the lively beach shacks and noisy bars. In the pre-pandemic days, the state hosted nine million tourists out of which about a million landed from foreign shores.

In the INDIA TODAY State of the States survey this year, Goa has emerged as the overall best performing small state and topped in the tourism, education, economy and infrastructure categories. The state has also secured its slot as the most improved small state in providing inclusive development. As the tourism sector gets back into action, chief minister Pramod Sawant is hopeful that mining, another of the state's growth drivers, will also see revival. In its heyday, the mining sector employed 300,000 people. It came to a grinding halt in 2018 following the Supreme Court quashing the second renewal of iron ore mining leases that were given to 88 companies in 2015.